This response contains some information on the average SEM scores as well as comments on the points (open text) raised in the SEM report. I then discuss changes made compared with previous years and plans for next year. Overall student performance (module marks) is reviewed and compared with that of last year. A final section tries to evaluate 'engagement' (lectures, video-recordings, weekly quiz).

Markus Eberhardt, June 13, 2024

(1) SEM Scores

I report the average SEM scores (out of 5) below (row labelled 'ME'), indicate how this changed from the previous academic year (row labelled 'r22/23') and provide the institutional average for reference (row labelled 'UoN').

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	OQ1	OQ2	AggSc
ME	4.36	4.28	3.81	4.31	4.41	4.31	4.26	4.60	4.33	29.74
r22/23	-.04	+.08	+.33	-.07	+.15	+.33	+.28	-.06	-.02	+1.06
UoN	4.26	4.19	4.02	4.36	4.37	4.11	4.12	N/A	N/A	29.43

Overall, the feedback indicates an improvement by 1 mark, with substantial constituent improvements in Q3, Q5, Q6 and Q7.

Q3 Activities and resources encouraged me to explore topics further
Q5 I know where to get help and support
Q6 Criteria for assessment are transparent and clearly explained
Q7 Workload is manageable

(2) Comments on Points raised in SEM (focus only on negative comments)

"The expectations for the group coursework could be better explained such as for task 3, I don't find it entirely clear what is expected for in contrast with semester 1's coursework."
RESPONSE: The coursework has not changed in four years, so it is surprising how much grief this seems to have caused students compared with previous cohorts. Task 3 asks to compute point and interval forecasts, to draw these in a graph, and to comment on the findings. It's very prescriptive, and few marks were deducted if people were quite brief in their discussion (since typically the models are not very good at forecasting unemployment change).

"Stata could also be introduced early in the semester" (A second comment suggests the 'organisation' of the computer classes could be improved, which I interpret to make a similar point).
RESPONSE: Students were already introduced to Stata in Semester 1. Regarding the use of Stata in the group assignment, the relevant class is around 4 weeks before the hand-in deadline. This aside, the pre-recorded computer labs were available from the very start of teaching, which cover all the tasks carried out in the group assignment at great length (with code).

"The Coursework was much more stressful than it needed to be. [...] Important information for the coursework was placed in the middle of near irrelevant information so everyday up until the due date, everyone I knew was changing something they hadn't seen because it was in the middle of a thick paragraph."
RESPONSE: It is a damning self-assessment if five or six year 2 students collectively cannot read through three pages of instructions over a four week period and filter out the relevant information to succeed in the group assignment.

"It was very difficult to learn how to code for this semester compared to last semester, and in the dofile that had content that could help us code for question 3, there was an issue. It wouldn't run properly and every group I know had issues with the code for that question and spent ages looking for alternatives."
RESPONSE: There was no error in the code. Instead, when copying and pasting code from the in-person labs and in particular from the pre-recorded lab, some students failed to appreciate the subtle differences in the coding of placeholders (so-called locals) in loops. This was a device to make the code more efficient, but in no way integral or even required for the task. Instead of running the different regression models and tests in a loop, it was perfectly fine to just copy and paste the three lines of code and simply adjust the lag lengths. Some students reached out to me and it was very easy and quick to point them to the error on their code.

"It would also be nice if we had had slightly more time to do the Coursework."
RESPONSE: Four weeks to do this task is more than ample time.

"Split into 2 1hr lectures instead of 1 2hr"
RESPONSE: This is a good idea, which surprisingly has rarely been mentioned.

"Didn't like the setup of the Moodle page for the module quite confusing" (A second comment made a similar point)
RESPONSE: The module follows the uniform setup put in place by the University. The Moodle update unfortunately made the appearance much less clear, though the basic structure is identical to that of all other modules on Moodle.

"I found it hard to follow in lectures as Markus spoke very quickly, I couldn't type everything I wanted to down and found it hard to follow at points."
RESPONSE: Every lecture is recorded.

"the content of this module is quite challenging especially for someone with no ALevel maths background"
RESPONSE: Any computations we do are so simple one can complete them on a basic calculator. Second year economics students should not be surprised (or alienated) to find the odd equation.

(3) Changes implemented

This year, a conscious effort was made to (a) provide yet more detail on how the assessment would look in lecture 1, and within this discussion (b) emphasise repeatedly (every lecture?) that 10 of the 15 multiple choice questions in the exam would be taken verbatim from the weekly quizzes. SEM feedback and stellar exam performance in the MCQ part suggests that these efforts were fruitful.

(4) Changes intended for next Session

The weekly quiz will gain even more prominence next year: any student who attempts all the quizzes and completes them (whatever the grade) will be given an extra 5 marks toward the module grade. This is in line with the practice in ECON2005 in Semester 1.

(5) Overall Student Performance

The below table indicates some descriptives, including the distribution of module marks (exam marks are separately reported in the Exam Feedback Form on Moodle). 76% of students achieved a First or II.1 in the module, compared with 67% last year. At the other end of the distribution, only half the proportion of students achieved Thirds or failed the module compared with last year. Separate feedback on the Group Assignment distributed to all students signalled that the analysis and especially the presentation of results had improved compared with earlier years.

	This year		Last year	
Number	309		278	
First	122	39%	100	36%
2(i)	115	37%	85	31%
2(ii)	47	15%	49	18%
Third	16	5%	27	10%
Fail	9	3%	17	6%
Mean	65.1		62.3	
SD	11		12.3	
Maximum	89		90	
Minimum	28		25	

(6) Engagement: Lectures, recordings, weekly quiz

Overall engagement was good. Lectures started out with around 50% of the 300+ students on the module, and a hard core of 80-100 stuck it out till the end.

Views of video recordings was decidedly mixed: for the TS topic, excluding the cointegration lectures, between 33% and 70% of students have viewed nothing at all. The remainder who watched the videos on average viewed close to or in excess of 80% of the individual recording. Only around 20-25% of students never watched any of the lectures on cointegration or LDV (those who watched again had very high viewing figures in excess of 90%), while the panel viewings match those discussed for TS. While viewing figures for the first revision lecture before the Easter break were high, comparatively many fewer students viewed the second revision lecture in the week before the exam (which was also attended by only around 80-100 students). Few students took advantage of the pre-recorded computer labs, even for the TS lectures which went through exercises very similar to that conducted in the Group Assignment. On average 40% of students viewed the TS pre-recorded labs, 18% those for LDV and 5% those for panel.

Engagement with the weekly quiz was very good. A total of 11,785 quizzes were attempted across the 8 topics, which translates in the average student completing each quiz 4.7 times. This is an astonishing number! Virtually every student on the module started at least one quiz, 91% completed 8 quizzes (though this may be the same quiz eight times rather than eight different quizzes), 43% completed 30 quizzes or more. 20% of all quizzes attempted were taken on the day of the exam, 66% in the 7 days before the exam. Only 27% of quizzes were taken during the Easter break, and a paltry 7% during the teaching term. Students thus seem to use this primarily as a device to cram before the exam, rather than to use this throughout the term to learn and solidify material taught.